



KINGPIN: Malhotra (second from left)

Dikshit had then termed this a political conspiracy and threatened to expose the dissidents after CBI ended its probe. With the party suffering a terrible loss of face, Congress President Sonia Gandhi summoned senior ministers who were allegedly behind the 'topple Sheila' campaign. The anti-Sheila faction also lobbied with-party general secretary Ashok Gehlot to present their side of the story.

The infighting in the party couldn't have come at a worse time. With little over a year left for the Assembly elections, the MLAs are getting jittery. After nine years in power, the Congress is bound to face an anti-incumbency wave. The latest scandal involving almost all the top guns in the party's Delhi unit only means that the wave will gather momentum as the elections draw near.

by Manoj Verma

Serving Scam on a Platter

DELHI In nearly nine years as Delhi chief minister, Sheila Dikshit has braved many challenges to her office. This time round, she may be facing her sternest test yet. As a land scam perpetrated by a roadside hawker-turned-multimillionaire Ashok

Malhotra rocked the capital, the chief minister's political rivals and her loyalists locked horns, thereby bringing the internal rivalries out in the open. After a raid at Malhotra's house, CBI claimed to have found several incriminating

documents related to a land scam along with Rs 17 lakh in cash, 7 kg gold and at least 50 luxury cars and 10 motorcycles all bearing VIP number plates. There were charges that Malhotra had been allotted the number plates for his cars on the basis of recommendations from the chief minister's office.

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The escalating bitter infighting in Kerala CPI(M), despite the suspension from the Politburo of V.S. Achuthanadan and Pinarayi Vijayan is further proof that the writ of A.K.G. Bhavan does not run beyond Delhi's Gole Market area.

VOICES



"The presidential race was run by the Left. They first laid down the parameters. Prakash Karat is the most powerful man in India today."

Karan Singh, Congress MP

"Periyar and Rajagopalachari shared such a beautiful friendship. But the present Tamil Nadu chief minister and the ex-chief minister are not even able to say hello."

Kanimozhi Karunanidhi, DMK MP

"The Indo-US nuclear deal is just clever wording, this will lead to our nuclear weapons programme being curbed and just cost a lot of money spent on achieving nothing."

Yashwant Sinha, former external affairs minister

"Pawar has to spend so much time looking after the Government in such an important ministry, does he have enough time for cricket?"

Kapil Dev, former cricket captain

"I am not scared of ageing. I'm 31 years old and I can wear a frock and still look good in it. But I don't want to pretend that I am not 31."

Sushmita Sen, actor

